Digital Intellectual History of Modern Korean Literary Studies: Bibliometric Analysis of Korea Citation Index and OpenAlex Data Sets

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Han Kang's reception of the 2024 Nobel Prize in Literature marks a watershed moment in the global recognition of Korean literature, signaling its emergence as a powerful art that articulates painful histories, individual traumas, and universal human conditions. This recognition reflects not only the artistic achievement of Korean literature itself but also decades of sustained scholarly engagement that has facilitated meaningful dialogue between Korean literature and global literary discourse. This study examines this complex cultural and academic interchange through two interrelated perspectives: the global academic discourse surrounding Korean literature and the development of Korean and English literary studies within South Korea, thereby illuminating how local and global literary discussions have evolved in mutual influence.

To trace these trajectories, we employ computational analysis of comprehensive bibliometric data from OpenAlex (Priem / Piwowar / Orr 2022), an extensive scholarly database encompassing various academic outputs including journal articles, monographs, and book chapters from worldwide institutions and publishers. While existing historiographies of Korean literary studies have often focused on specific geographic realms or relied primarily on qualitative analyses, our study provides a data-driven perspective on how Korean literature has been studied, interpreted, and disseminated across global academic communities between 2000 and 2024. By analyzing publication metadata, we examine three key dimensions: 1) the evolution of research topics and theoretical approaches using structural topic modeling, particularly focusing on how local literary themes intersect with global literary discourse, 2) the changing institutional affiliations of contributing scholars to map the transnational expansion of Korean literary studies, and 3) temporal citation patterns revealing how research on Korean literature has been integrated into broader conversations in world literature, comparative literature, and literary theory.

This global perspective on Korean literary studies will be complemented by our analysis of how Korean literature has been studied within South Korea's own academic sphere. Drawing from approximately 17,000 research articles published between 2002 and 2024 across 40 major journals indexed in the Korea Citation Index (KCI), we examine the internal dynamics of Korean literary scholarship. Through computational analysis of article titles, abstracts, and keywords, we map the evolution of research topics and theoretical approaches in modern Korean literary studies, contributing to the understanding of computational social science research processes within specific academic contexts (Jeon et al. 2023). Our citation network analysis reveals the theoretical foundations of contemporary Korean literary scholarship, identifying key theorists and theoretical frameworks that have shaped the field. This examination of domestic Korean literary studies provides crucial context for understanding how local scholarly discourse has developed in dialogue with both traditional Korean literary criticism and global theoretical trends. The interplay between domestic and international perspectives becomes particularly evident when we consider how Korean scholars have increasingly integrated global theoretical frameworks while maintaining distinctive interpretative approaches rooted in Korean literary and cultural traditions.

Additionally, we analyze the development of English literary studies in South Korea as a significant academic field that has mediated Korean literature and the global literary trends, shaping the nation's engagement with world literature over the past 70 years. This analysis focuses particularly on The Journal of English Language and Literature, the preeminent academic journal in Korean English studies, along with 32 other South Korean academic journals in the field. Through network analysis and visualization techniques applied to publication metadata and keyword co-occurrence patterns, similar to approaches used in analyzing other Korean academic fields (Kim 2023), we map both the diachronic evolution

(1955-2024) and synchronic topology (2002-2024) of English literary studies in South Korea. Our study contributes to a macroscopic examination of Korean English literature research since the 1950s, offering insights into both its historical development and contemporary dynamics. It comprehends the overarching themes and concepts that have captured the attention of Korean scholars of English language and literature, as well as the interrelationships and shifts among these topics over time. The study also provides valuable clues for understanding the processes by which the English language and literature have been received and developed within Korean humanities academia and literary field. By illuminating these dynamics, our research underscores the historical significance of English literature in forming Korean culture, and enhances our grasp of the interplay between global literary trends and local discourses of literature in South Korea.

Our research reveals several significant patterns in these dynamic academic exchanges. First, we observe the multifaceted interaction between local and global perspectives in Korean literary studies, demonstrating how Korean literature has become a crucial site for exploring human conditions through its unique historical and cultural contexts. Second, we trace how English literature has played a vital role in shaping South Korean cultural discourses and literary studies, establishing frameworks through which Korean scholars engage with global literary trends. Finally, our analysis illuminates the growing reciprocity between these streams of scholarship, as evidenced by increasing cross-citations and theoretical exchanges. This comprehensive digital humanities approach to South Korean intellectual history provides empirical evidence for the sustained development of literary studies as a vital field in local and global academia, contextualizing Han Kang's Nobel recognition as part of a longer trajectory of academic engagement with Korean literature worldwide. Moreover, by examining both the global reception of Korean literature and Korea's engagement with world literature, our study offers vital insights into the processes by which local and global literary discourses interact, evolve, and enrich each other. This research enhances our understanding of how national literatures participate in world literature while simultaneously being shaped by their engagement with foreign literary traditions, contributing to a more nuanced comprehension of modern intellectual history in an increasingly interconnected global literary landscape.

Bibliography

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